



Internally displaced girls walk through Sadhe camp in Iraq, near the border with Iran. The temperature in the area can rise to over 45 degrees during summer, and the camp can become flooded in autumn and winter. (Photo: UNHCR/H.Caux, July 2010)

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## Internal displacement in the **Middle East**

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In 2010, new fighting and displacement in Yemen led the number of people internally displaced in the Middle East to increase. The figure in the Middle East reached 3.9 million at the end of the year; however the number of IDPs in the rest of the region remained stable and there was relatively little new displacement, while few IDPs achieved a durable solution as past situations remained unresolved.

Over the ten years to 2010, the number of IDPs in the Middle East more than trebled from a little over one million at the start of the decade. Most of those IDPs in 2000 had been displaced in Iraq by the persecution of Saddam Hussein's government or by the Iran-Iraq war, in Lebanon by the country's long-running sectarian civil war, or in Syria due to Israel's

occupation of the Golan Heights. Discriminatory government policies had also displaced Palestinians in Israel as well as in the Occupied Palestinian Territory (OPT) and Kurds in Syria.

While many of these policies and occupations have continued to cause displacement, the last ten years have also been marked by numerous "asymmetric" conflicts in which regular armed forces have carried out counter-insurgency campaigns against militant groups. These militants have often been in the midst of civilians, and their guerilla tactics and the disproportionate force used against them have caused heightened civilian casualties and often massive displacement.

From 2000, in OPT, the Israeli army engaged in continuing low-intensity conflict with Palestinian militants, involving spo-



radic large-scale military operations in West Bank towns and cities and repeated attacks on Gaza. At the end of 2010, over 20,000 people in Gaza were still displaced, two years after the massive three-week Israeli attack of 2008-2009.

The Israeli army also embarked on a massive military campaign against Hezbollah in southern Lebanon in 2006, which led to the displacement of over a quarter of the entire population. Many of them had settled in Beirut by 2010. In 2007, tens of thousands of Palestinian refugees in Lebanon were forced to flee the Nahr el-Bared camp after it was destroyed in a bombardment by Lebanese armed forces ostensibly targeting militants.

Following the invasion of Iraq in 2003, the primary cause of displacement was fighting between multinational forces and both Sunni and Shi'ite insurgents. This peaked between 2005 and 2007, and resulted in the internal displacement of well over a million people, almost all of whom remained displaced as of 2010. In Yemen's northern governorates and in particular in Sa'ada, successive cycles of rebellion by the Al-Houthi group and counter-insurgency campaigns by the Yemeni and Saudi armies led the internally displaced population to rise to over 340,000 at the height of the conflict in 2010.

There were also smaller instances of displacement due to localised inter-communal violence. In disputed areas bordering the Kurdish northern regions of Iraq, violence caused the displacement of some returning Kurds, Arab residents and members of various minorities including Christians, Turkmen, Yazidis, and Shabaks.

## Protection concerns facing IDPs

In 2010, one in every 11 Iraqis was still internally displaced. Security had improved to some extent, but IDPs continued to face threats to their physical integrity, and insecurity remained the main concern of both returnees and IDPs. In addition, the

government had proven unable to provide adequate essential services to IDPs, including the most vulnerable women, children and older people among them. They struggled to access basic necessities, and found it hard to access rations through the Public Distribution System (PDS) if they did not have valid PDS cards in the governorate they had been displaced to.

In Yemen, despite the ceasefire agreement of 2010, intermittent violence and widespread mines and other unexploded ordnance continued to put IDPs at risk. They continued to go without basic services, and food rations were halved during the year. Internally displaced children and others from conflict areas were killed or injured by direct shelling and mines; there were also continuing reports of child recruitment by several parties to the conflict in Al-Houthi-controlled areas. Exposure to violence had a traumatic impact on IDP children.

Internally displaced Palestinians faced ongoing discrimination and in many cases the constant threat of secondary displacement. In Lebanon, those displaced from Nahr el-Bared due to the restrictions faced a direct threat to their livelihood and access to social services.

The nature of the region's conflicts and counter-insurgency operations have led IDPs and the agencies seeking to assist them to face significant restrictions on their movement. In the West Bank in 2010, IDPs were unable to access their land and assistance was impeded by a system of over 550 checkpoints and barriers that limited access to many Palestinian enclaves. In Iraq, where many concrete barriers continued to mark sectarian boundaries, the insecurity and restrictions imposed by regional governments stopped IDPs from moving between regions. In Lebanon, the army severely restricted access to Nahr el-Bared camp and the adjacent areas, while in Yemen government restrictions impeded the movement of IDPs and the access of humanitarian agencies to affected areas.

The access to IDPs has been further complicated by the fact that the overwhelming majority have sought refuge in cities and towns where they have dispersed among the general population. In the absence of government or international assistance, they have had to rely on their hosts, often placing a heavy burden on them over time. In Yemen, camps provided shelter and assistance to only one in eight IDPs in 2010, while the relationship between the IDPs outside camps and their host communities became strained over limited resources.

Despite extensive efforts by international agencies, the status of internally displaced women has remained particularly difficult. In all countries, displaced women who have become heads of households have had to support their children and older members of their family without a steady income, relying on piecemeal support. Displaced women are struggling to merely provide adequate food, not to mention housing, health care and other services. In Iraq, IOM reported that nearly 40 per cent of women heading displaced households who had returned were unable to work due to health problems or social pressures. Of those who were capable of working, 71 per cent were unemployed. In Iraq and also in Yemen, where domestic violence and marital rape are not criminalised, there has also been concern that displacement has increased significantly the exposure of children and women to domestic violence and other sexual or gender-based violence.

## Protracted displacement

By 2010, well over a third of IDPs in the region were trapped in protracted displacement, including in situations where the conflict which had displaced them had ended. For some, the discrimination which had led to their displacement continued. This was the case for Kurds displaced in Syria: the “Arab belt” project in which they had been forced from their homes along the Turkish border had been suspended in 1976, but there were no reports of those displaced achieving durable solutions. In the West Bank, the government of Israel’s continued planning of new settlements and infrastructure prevented durable solutions for people displaced by its earlier activities.

Political considerations also continued to prevent the achievement of durable solutions. For example, the government of Syria had officially maintained returns as the durable solution to the people displaced from the Golan Heights so as not to weaken its claim over the Golan. The Israeli government had not entertained the return of IDPs within Israel, in case this paved the way for the return of Palestinian refugees from neighbouring countries.

The rate of returns in Iraq dropped from a high of 17,000 per month in July 2009 to 9,000 in June 2010, while 38 per cent of those that did return did not feel safe and about half found their homes damaged or occupied by militias or other IDPs. Many IDPs remained reluctant to return to their place of origin, with those in Yemen and Iraq still citing fear of insecurity and of reprisals among the principal concerns in 2010. In these countries and also in Lebanon, the lack of social services, infrastructure and livelihood opportunities in return areas also

put them off. In Yemen a quarter of the IDPs had no intention of returning, while in Iraq the percentage of IDPs who preferred to integrate locally increased from 30 per cent in 2006 to 37 per cent in 2010.

## National and international responses

In 2010, the RSG on IDPs visited Yemen in April and Iraq in September, and advocated for the development of strategies on durable solutions to displacement and raised awareness among donors of the need to provide adequate funding. In November 2010, the UN launched its second consolidated appeal in response to the situation in northern Yemen, after adopting the cluster system there in February 2010. Humanitarian agencies also managed to negotiate the resumption of their access and assistance in Sa’ada in February 2010, only to see it curtailed by further government restrictions and insecurity in the following months.

Overall, there was little evidence of the participation of IDPs in the planning and implementation of relevant policies and programmes during 2010. The impartiality of the humanitarian response also remained in question. It was still delivered by teams associated with parties to conflict, as in Lebanon where Hezbollah has been a major source of assistance, and Iraq where reconstruction has often been led by US military-led teams. The gradual departure of US forces from Iraq can pave the way for international humanitarians to reinforce their neutrality and encourage a more participatory approach.

| Country                        | Number of IDPs (rounded) | Government figures                      | UN figures                                      | Other figures                                                                                                   | Comments                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Iraq                           | <b>2,800,000</b>         |                                         | 1,300,000 (UNHCR, January 2011)                 | 2,170,000 (Iraqi Red Crescent Organisation, June 2008); 2,840,000 (IOM, November 2010)                          | UNHCR figures are based on the number of IDPs registered by the Iraqi authorities since 2006. IOM estimate includes people internally displaced before 2006.                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Israel                         | <b>Undetermined</b>      |                                         |                                                 | 150,000 (Cohen, 2001); 420,000 (BADIL, 2006)                                                                    | Most of those included in these estimates are the children and grandchildren of people originally displaced.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Lebanon                        | <b>At least 76,000</b>   | 40,000 to 70,000 since civil war (2007) | 27,000 from Nahr el-Bared (UNRWA, October 2010) | 50,000–300,000 (USCRI, 2005); 600,000 prior to July 2006 (USDoS, 2006); 23,000 (Lebanon Support, February 2010) | Different populations are included; those displaced by the 2007 siege of Nahr el-Bared camp for Palestinian refugees, the 2006 Israel-Hezbollah conflict, and the 1975-1990 civil war and Israeli invasions. Numbers of IDPs remaining from the 2006 Israeli incursion are reportedly not significant.                                                         |
| Occupied Palestinian Territory | <b>At least 160,000</b>  |                                         | At least 20,500 (OCHA, November 2009)           | 129,000 (BADIL, December 2009); 4,700 (Harmkod, December 2009); 24,800 homes demolished (ICAHD, July 2010)      | OCHA refers to IDPs receiving rental allowance in Gaza or displaced due to house demolitions in West Bank. BADIL refers to people displaced from 1967 to 2008 excluding the offensive in Gaza. Harmkod indicates the number of revoked residency permits in 2008 not included in BADIL figures. ICAHD has reported 24,800 homes demolished since 1967 to 2010. |
| Syria                          | <b>433,000</b>           | 433,000 (2007)                          |                                                 |                                                                                                                 | The figure includes children of people originally displaced from the Golan.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Yemen                          | <b>About 250,000</b>     |                                         | At least 225,000 (OCHA, November 2010)          |                                                                                                                 | It has not been possible to verify the sustainability of returns since the number of IDPs peaked in early 2010. Other internal conflicts caused the displacement of 6,700 to 12,000 Yemenis, many of whom reportedly returned.                                                                                                                                 |